

Colorado Field Ornithologists Sight Record Form

(This is a two-page report. Please print or type. Attach photographs and additional pages if necessary.)

6-1(A)

Each table cell will automatically enlarge as you type!

Red 2/5/01 wpl

CFO-RC FILE X:

RESULTS:

Species:(Common Name): LESSER BLACK-BACKED GULL		(Scientific Name) <i>Larus fuscus</i>
Date(s) of occurrence: 12 March 2000		
Number of birds seen: One of this age class	Sex: Unknown	Plumage: First-Basic
Exact Location: Lake Loveland		
County: Larimer	Nearest town: Loveland	Elevation: 5005 msl
Length of observation: Observed during a roughly 15-minute period off and on.		Time(s) of observation: Approximately 5:45 MST
Other observers who saw the bird(s) with you: Tony Leukering		
Other Observers who independently saw the bird(s):		
Light Conditions (quality; direction relative to bird(s); position: Sunset, partly cloudy. Facing east.		
Optical equipment used: 8 x 40 Binoculars, 32X Bushnell Spotting Scope		
Distance from bird(s) (estimated unless otherwise noted): Difficult to judge, perhaps 250 yards		
Was bird(s) photographed? No	If so, have you submitted photos?	
Who took the photographs?		
Describe the general and specific habitat in which the bird(s) occurred: Open water lake		
Describe the bird's behavior (flying, feeding, habits, behaviors used in identifying the Species or in supporting the identification): Observed briefly while landing but otherwise bird only observed while swimming		
Describe the bird in detail. This is the most important part of this report. Include the overall size and shape and how you placed the bird in the general group that you did. Give complete details of plumage, including head, throat, undersides, nape, back, wings and tail. Give particular emphasis to marks you used to identify the bird(s). Describe other important details, such as color and shape of bill, legs, eye, (etc.) that were important in making the identification. (Fill out this portion even if photographs are submitted; you may attach additional sheets, drawings, field sketches or copy field notes):		
During March 2000, the Loveland area experienced a major incursion of gulls of various species that included multiple Lesser Black-backed Gulls. Lake Loveland appeared to be the major roosting site for the area that is evidenced by the thousands of gulls that roosted on the lake in the evenings. The numbers of birds and the diversity associated was amazing for such an inland locale. On 12 March, besides typical wintering gulls, the lake hosted Slaty-backed Gull, Glaucous Gull, Great Black-backed Gull, and at least four different Lesser Black-backed of all four-year cohorts. One Lesser Black-backed was in definitive first-basic plumage and specific traits associated with that bird are described below. Some subtle identification points were not observed due to the fading light and distance from the observer. Overall Size: Was much smaller than nearby first-winter Great Black-backed Gull and appeared even slightly smaller than Herring Gulls, seemingly similar in size as California Gulls. Overall shape was slender and attenuated due to a long wing-tip extension and relatively slim bill. Bill: Though difficult to fully discern from the distance, the bill appeared all black, relatively thin, long, and with a slight gonydeal angle. This differed markedly with the large, thick, bulbous-tipped bill of a Great Black-backed and seemed even less massive than adjacent Herring Gulls. Head and Neck: Somewhat whitish (whiter than remainder of body) with quite heavy diffuse streaking throughout (especially on the rear crown, auriculars, and nape); the forehead, lorals, and throat appeared less streaked. Upperparts: Mantle looked dark brown but mottled with some whitish/lighter brown scalloping throughout. The scapulars and coverts appeared mostly dark brown but with quite extensive splotching of white. Tertiaries appeared almost black with white fringes. Underparts: Mainly dusky due to melding of heavy brown flank streaking. Anterior portions of the breast were whiter. Tail: The tail appeared all dark while swimming but was partially obscured by the primary tips. Wingtips: The primary tips appeared wholly black and extended well past the tail tip. Leg Color: Not observed.		
Describe bird's call or song: None noted		

Discuss similar species and how you eliminated them:

Great Black-backed Gull: The subject bird was significantly smaller (one-third smaller) than Great Black-backed Gull with a much thinner and smaller bill. Besides being considerably larger in overall size and shape (more bulky), first definitive basic Great Black-backs would have a noticeably whiter head and neck owing to the far lesser degrees of brown streaking. Great Black-backs would also be lighter mantled and winged due to heavier scalloping of white mantle and covert fringes. A first-winter Great Black-backed Gull was also present at this locale and was compared directly with this and other Lesser Black-backed Gulls. Documentation for the Great Black-backed Gull has also been submitted to the committee.

Herring Gull: The subject bird was seemingly slightly smaller than nearby Herring Gulls, though considerable overlap between Lesser Black-backed Gulls and Herring Gulls can occur based upon sexual size dimorphism and genetics within each species. I have observed small runty Herring Gulls that very closely approximated that of a typical Lesser Black-backed Gull. Plumage characteristics are more significant for separation. First winter Herring Gulls (which were also present for direct comparison) would have a darker muddy-colored head, breast, and belly due to considerable blending of streaking. This streaking will actually make it appear that the bird has completely brown underparts instead of the noticeable light but heavily-streaked underparts of a Lesser Black-backed Gull. The upperparts of young Herring's would also appear more uniformly dark because of the reduced amount of white feather fringes. The tertials would also be darker owing to a thinner band of white outer fringing.

California Gull: Though somewhat similar in size to California Gulls, Lesser Black-backed Gulls differ in morphology and plumage by having rather thicker mandibles and a slightly thicker build. The bill of a young California Gull would be bicolored pink-and-black with only the terminal tip being black. The upperparts of a California Gull would also be browner and would lack the checkered pattern of Lesser Black-backed Gulls.

What is your prior experience with this and similarly appearing species? Have observed numerous other Lesser Black-backed Gulls in Colorado, Wisconsin, Minnesota, Texas, Florida, Pennsylvania, New Jersey, and in Europe.

List books, guides, recordings or other sources consulted and how this influenced your identification (during and after observation): None

This report is from notes made during or after XX observation or later from memory

Date of written report:

Reporting observer: Larry Semo

Signature:



Reporting Observer's Address: 9054 Dover Street

City: Westminster

State: Colorado

Zip: 80021

Send report to:
Colorado Birds Record Committee
c/o Bill Lisowsky
2919 Silverplume Dr.
Ft. Collins, Co. 80526